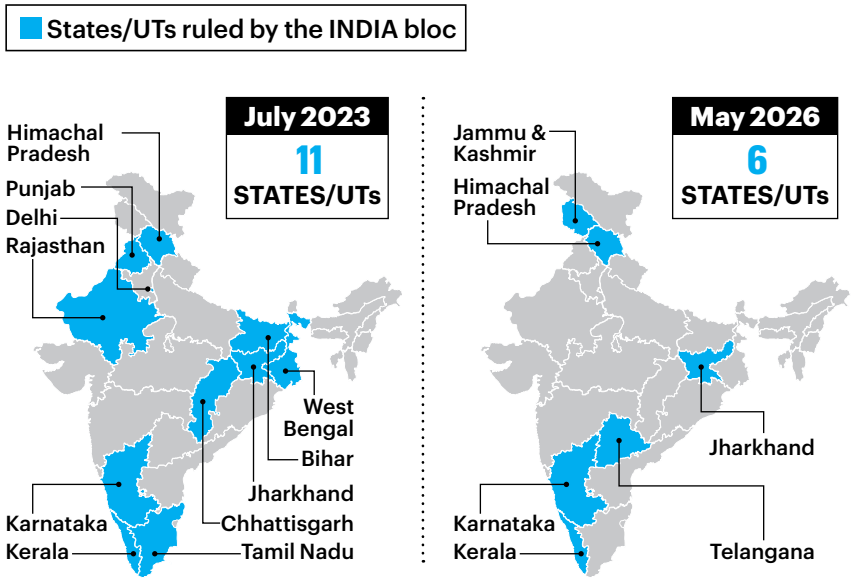
# SHRINKING FOOTPRINT

**Since its formation in 2023, the INDIA bloc has lost half its turf**




## A Growing Divide

Inside the bloc, unity is flickering. After the setbacks in Maharashtra and Bihar, ties between the Congress and its regional partners—Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) and the RJD—have slipped from cordial to chilly. Talk of a merger between the two Nationalist Congress Party factions could yet cost the alliance another founder member, Sharad Pawar. In Uttar Pradesh, the Samajwadi Party, while cooperating with the Congress in Parliament, shows little appetite for on-ground coordination ahead of the 2027 assembly election. The AAP has already exited the bloc. In Punjab, also due for polls next year, there is effectively no INDIA bloc left to speak of.

Meanwhile, Rahul Gandhi, the leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, spent the assembly campaign attacking Mamata, arguing that the TMC regime's failures—corruption, polarisation and weak governance—had enabled the BJP's rise in Bengal. After the TMC's rout, however, he recast himself as a voice for Opposition unity, endorsing Mamata's claim that more than 100 seats had been "stolen" and extending the same explanation to the Congress's collapse in Assam.

The shift has not been universally welcomed within his party. On May 5, Rahul himself noted that some Congress leaders were privately gloating over the TMC's defeat, warning that the BJP's victory poses a collective, existential threat to all Opposition parties. This underscores a familiar contradiction: while the Congress's central leadership seeks a national anti-BJP front, state units often view regional INDIA allies as their immediate rivals. For many in the Bengal Congress, Mamata's defeat is not a democratic setback but a political opening.

In Tamil Nadu, the Congress has already abandoned its long-time ally, the DMK, prompting the latter to declare it as the end of INDIA. Rahul had moved swiftly to congratulate Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), a day after it stunned both Dravidian majors. The TVK has fallen just 10 seats short of a majority; the Congress's five MLAs could help reduce that gap. Notably, a section within the Congress—among them data cell and professionals' Congress head Praveen Chakravarty and party whip in the Lok Sabha Manickam Tagore—had pushed for a pre-poll alliance with Vijay, only to be overruled by party president Mallikarjun Kharge and the state unit.

## The Challenge Ahead

The latest setbacks come barely a fortnight after the Opposition's most consequential parliamentary win in years. On April 17, a united INDIA bloc defeated the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026—the Modi government's bid to expand the Lok Sabha to 850 seats and advance delimitation based on the 2011 Census. The tally was 298 in favour and 230 against. The government, needing 352 of the 528 members present, fell short by 54—the first time in 12 years that one of its constitutional amendments failed. The coalition that delivered the blow included the DMK and the TMC, whose MPs voted as one. The test for the bloc is whether it can sustain that unity till 2029, as state-level equations shift.

The INDIA bloc's problem is no longer merely arithmetic; it is territorial and psychological. Its five-state footprint is geographically lopsided—three governments in the South, one in Himachal Pradesh and one in Jharkhand. The Congress, the only party with a plausible claim to national opposition leadership, risks being recast as a southern party. Its allies, meanwhile, are strongest precisely where they must also compete with it.

Across the aisle stands a BJP that governs 17 states/ UTs on its own, with NDA partners running another five. Together, they govern more than 70 per cent of India's population and over two-thirds of its landmass. The contrast is stark: the INDIA bloc can still block a constitutional amendment in Parliament, but it is steadily losing the republic beyond it. In state after state, allies turn adversaries, local ambitions trump national strategy, and the BJP harvests the fallout. To reclaim India, INDIA must first decide whether it is an alliance, an arrangement, or merely an acronym that has outlived its purpose. ■